# 10

# The Proteas and me

**Some people aren't going to like this chapter, but I've always believed you have to call it like you see it.**

I think if we're honest with ourselves – and I'm talking about the players and the fans – we've got to admit that the Proteas have underachieved in international cricket over the past decade. Given the talent we have had at our disposal, we should have won at least one ODI World Cup and been consistently challenging the Aussies as the top Test team in the world.

Yes, we have hit the number-one spot in both ODI and Test cricket, but only briefly. One great highlight – and, ironically, one that I played no part in – was the historic 2009 Test series win in Australia. It's a pity we haven't been able to build on that victory, though. The stone-cold fact is that, when it comes to the crunch – especially in limited-overs cricket – we fail, time and time again. Painful World Cup after painful World Cup. And believe me when I say that no one has felt the pain more acutely than me.

I have thought long and hard about including this chapter in the book. Should I tell you why I think the Proteas have underachieved? I certainly get asked often enough by both cricket supporters and the press to know that it's an issue. Or should I rather keep my mouth shut? I know where *your* vote lies – you wouldn't be reading this book if you thought I should keep my mouth shut – but I do run the risk of sounding like a big fat hypocrite mouthing off when I was part of almost all those teams that failed at the final hurdle.

But I have decided to talk and be damned.

These are my honest views on where I think our national cricket team falls short. This is not press speculation, but a firsthand account of someone